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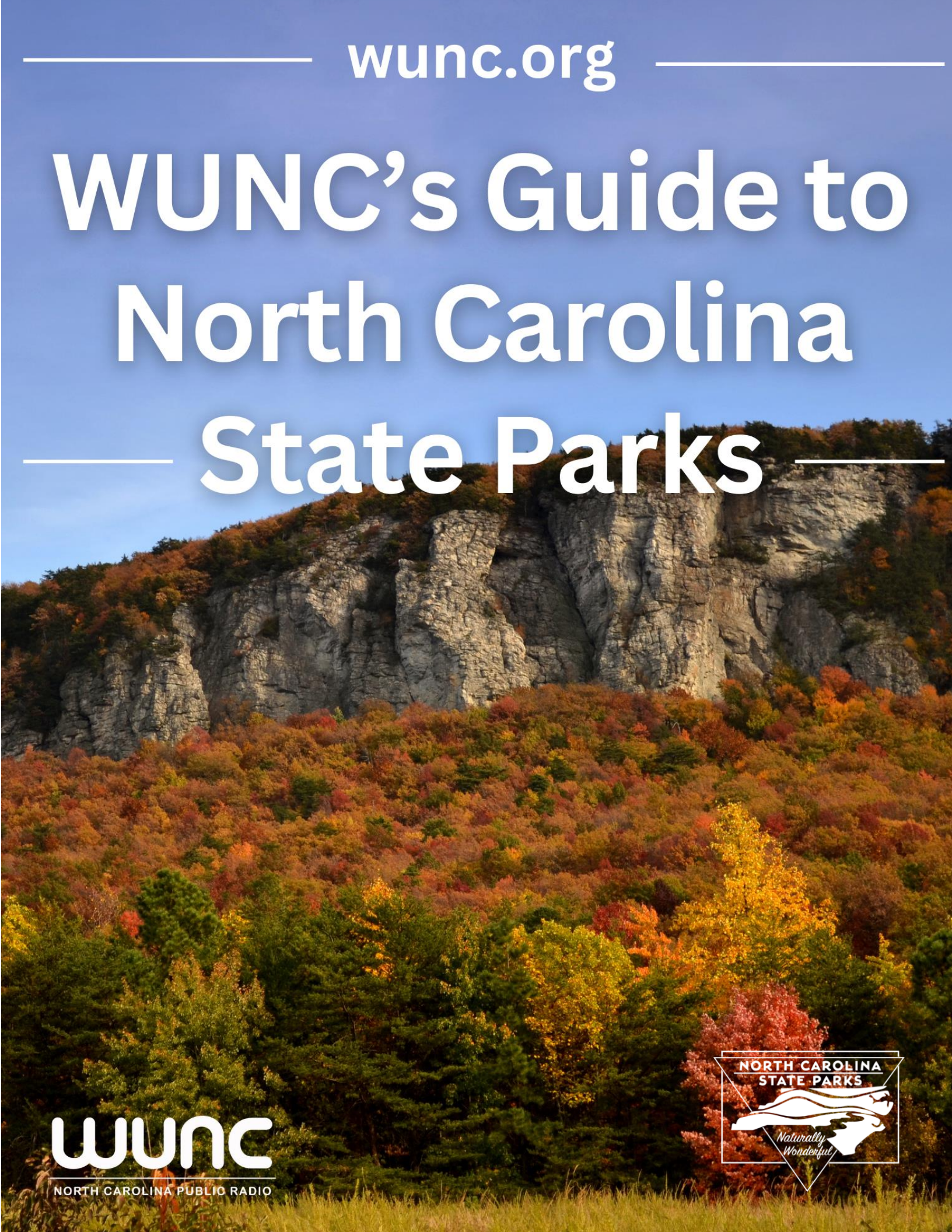
WUNC's Guide to North Carolina State Parks



WUNC
NORTH CAROLINA PUBLIC RADIO

NORTH CAROLINA STATE PARKS
Naturally Wonderful

WUNC staff members put together a guide to some of their favorite state parks in North Carolina. In this guide you'll find hikes easy enough for beginners, lazy river floating, ferry boat marshland tours, overnight excursions, and much more! A special thanks to the team at the North Carolina State Parks for contributing to this guide as well.

WUNC Radio is a public radio station that provides high-quality local and national news, cultural and entertainment content to create a more informed and engaged community. The station is based in the Raleigh/Durham/Chapel Hill area of North Carolina (also referred to as "the Triangle") and serves a large part of the state, from Rocky Mount to the Outer Banks.

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Coastal Plains Region

Carolina Beach State Park

"My family LOVES Carolina Beach State Park! We've had great camping experiences, and one of my favorite things about this park is all the different environments you can find in one park. And you can't beat the access to the beach - or the Venus flytraps!"

- **Amanda Magnus,** *Embodied* Executive Editor

Photo Credit: Charlie Peek

Photo Credit: Unknown

Hammocks Beach State Park

"There's no better way to explore North Carolina's marshlands and oceanfront than by ferry boat and a nice long beach walk - both found at Hammocks Beach State Park. Leave the car behind on the mainland and look for herons and ducks on the ride out to Bear Island. Then, explore the beach on foot and watch the sandpipers and plovers play tag with the waves. (Yes, I'm into birdwatching...and this park does not disappoint.) A campsite reservation on the island may be difficult to pin down in the busy summer months, but the sunset views are worth it! You can try to beat the rush on a weekday or in the off-season. In any case, always remember to check the ferry schedule!"

- **Kaia Findlay,** *Embodied* Producer

Photo Credit: Charlie Peek

Photo Credit: Kaia Findlay

Jockey's Ridge State Park

"All three of my kids have taken class trips to Jockeys Ridge State Park. As a chaperone, I treasure the memories of watching them run up and down the tallest dunes on the east coast or trudging through the pools of water that collect in the valleys. They were too young for hang gliding, but the hikes and the views were spectacular, especially at sunset."

- **Dave DeWitt,** Feature News Editor

"A hands-on way to visit Jockey's Ridge is with our weekly Soundside Explorers program, where visitors catch critters in the Roanoke Sound. It is amazing what we find using nets in the water along the shoreline. This program, and other programs like "Kayak the Sound," are a great way to explore Jockey's Ridge."

- **Austin Paul,** Jockey's Ridge State Park Ranger

Photo Credit: Dave DeWitt

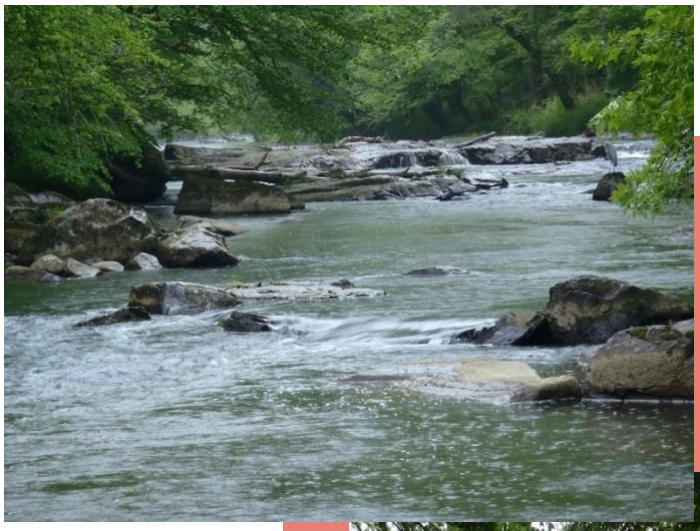
Photo Credit: Dave DeWitt

Piedmont Region

Eno River State Park

"When I first moved to North Carolina from Georgia, one of the first places I visited was the Eno. It was the beginning of spring when my friends took me to a secret nook near the edge of the river. I felt like I crossed over the Bridge to Terabithia. The vibrant white and pink flowers danced in the wind while little turtles peeked their heads out of the water to see who found their oasis. The Eno is full of little surprises, from the Teepees on the mountain to a random fireplace in the middle of the woods. It's the place I go to when I want to find peace or need a little adventure."

Photo Credit: Dave Cook



- **Kamaya Truitt,** Director of Youth Reporting, New Talent and Community Partnerships

"Unlike some of its more remote sister parks, Eno River State Park is located in the Triangle and provides an unexpected oasis of calm while the surrounding area moves with the pace of urban growth. Many visitors come to the park to hike and sit along the river, slowing down and reconnecting with nature."

- **Kim Radewicz,** Eno River State Park Superintendent Ranger

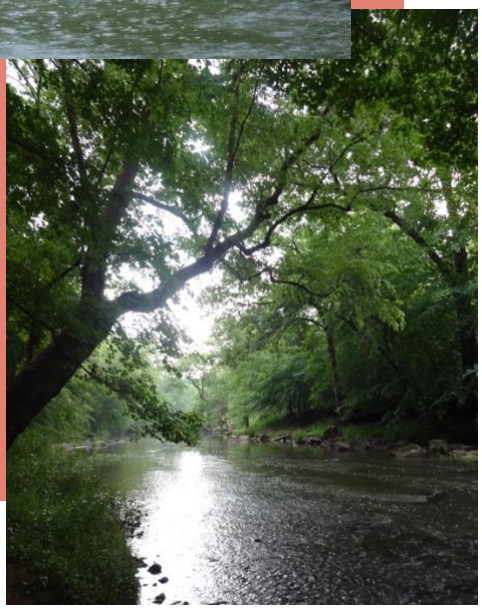


Photo Credit: Jason Brown

Falls Lake State Recreation Area

"My family lives just a few miles from Falls Lake, which is my most frequently visited spot. The massive man-made body of water, which provides drinking water for the city of Raleigh and helps control flooding along the Neuse River, is technically a state "recreation area." We've got kayaks and a paddleboard for on-the-water fun; we also utilize a portion of the Mountains to Sea Trail, which runs along the lake. There are also places to camp, fish, picnic, and there are even some playgrounds on the state and county property adjacent to the lake. The trails are an underused resource and provide an almost deceptive reprieve from the growing hustle, bustle and traffic of our capital/Triangle region."

- **Jeff Tiberii,** *Due South* Co-Host

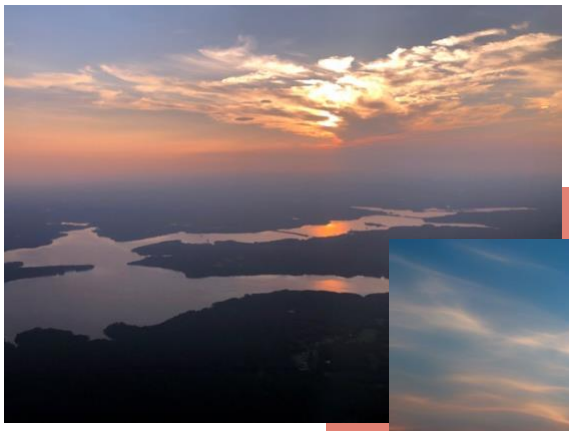


Photo Credit: Picasa

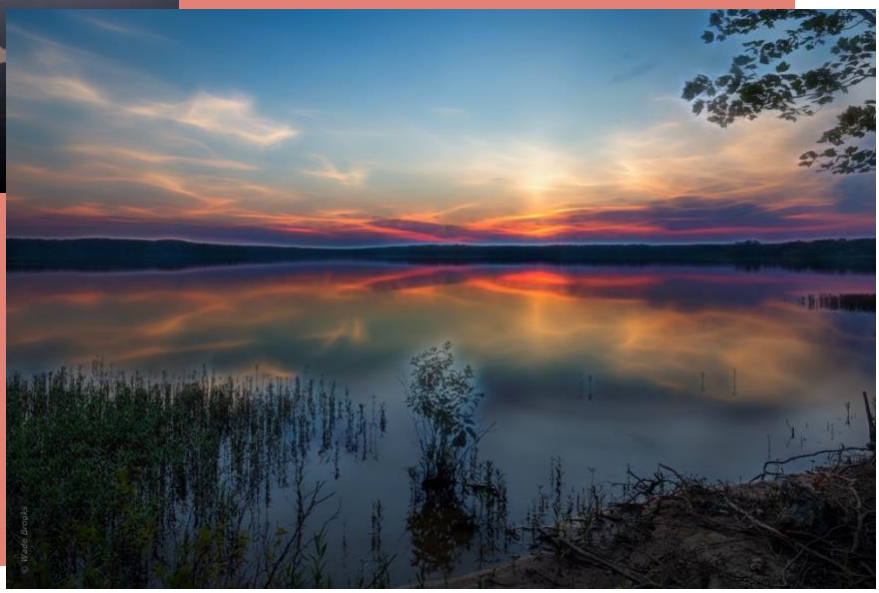


Photo Credit: Wade Brooks

Hanging Rock State Park

"Hanging Rock State Park is beautiful at any time of year, but in the fall, the temperature is perfect -- and the mountains are alive with color. The hike to the top is not too long or intense, so it's great for families and beginning hikers. You can pack a lunch and hang out at the top of Hanging Rock for a while, enjoying the vistas while you eat! It's also an easy day trip if you live in the Triangle or the Triad. If you plan to go on the weekend, get there early to beat the crowds!"

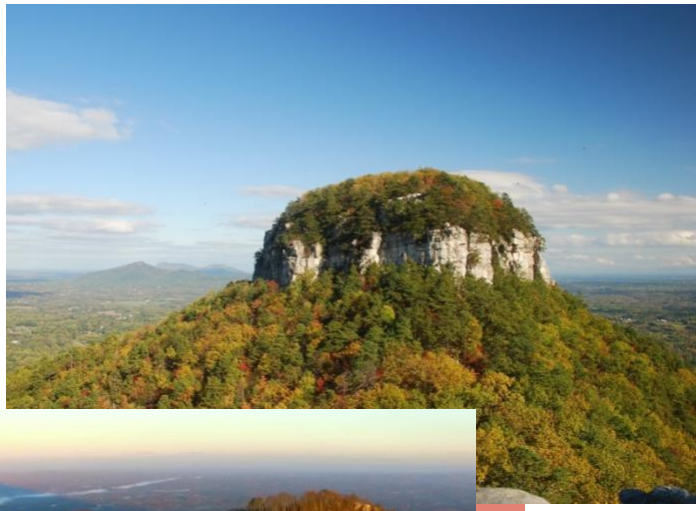
- **Anisa Khalifa,** Podcast Producer and *The Broadside* Host

Photo Credit: Edward Farr

Photo Credit: Jason Anthony

Pilot Mountain State Park

Photo Credit: MWindsor



"Pilot Mountain State Park is a great place for an overnight camping trip and plenty of hiking - the Grindstone Trail to the summit is steep but rewarding, offering a commanding view of Yadkin Valley--and Mount Airy, the town on which Andy Griffith's Mayberry is based, is not too far away."

- **Rusty Jacobs,** Voting and Election Integrity Reporter

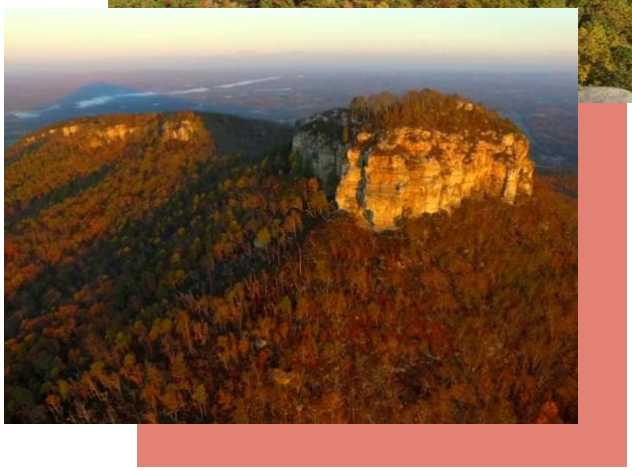


Photo Credit: Max Messinger

"For hundreds of years, travelers have been intrigued by Pilot Mountain, the westernmost peak in the Sauratown Range, and easily the most recognizable. To Native Americans, it was a natural navigational beacon. To settlers heading south on the Great Wagon Road, it indicated they would soon arrive in North Carolina. And today, the state park still beckons travelers to experience a foretaste of the mountains with its challenging trails and breathtaking views."

- **Jason Anthony,** Pilot Mountain State Park Superintendent Ranger

William B. Umstead State Park

"There are so many great state parks in North Carolina, it's hard to pick just one. But one of my favorites is right here in the Triangle. It's such a treat to have Umstead State Park so close to home. When it's a nice day, and we don't have any plans, my family and I often pack a backpack and some lunch and hit the trails with our young daughters. There are miles and miles of trails at Umstead! We love stopping for breaks and picnics, especially near Reedy Creek Lake, where we can spot some fish, too. "

- **Elizabeth Baier,** Editor for Race, Class, & Communities

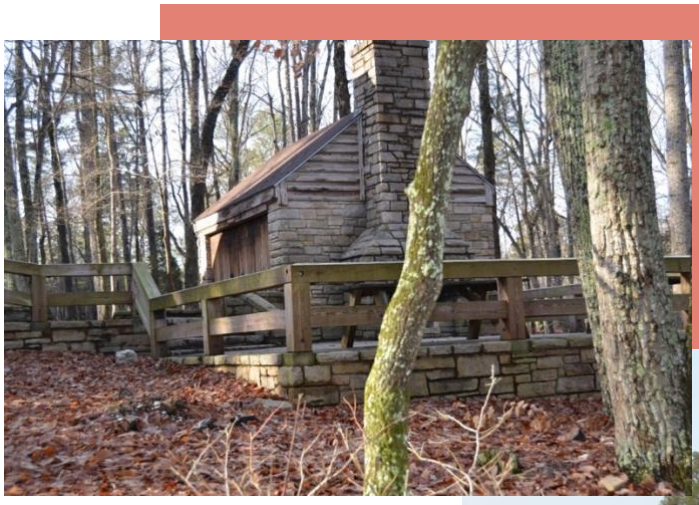
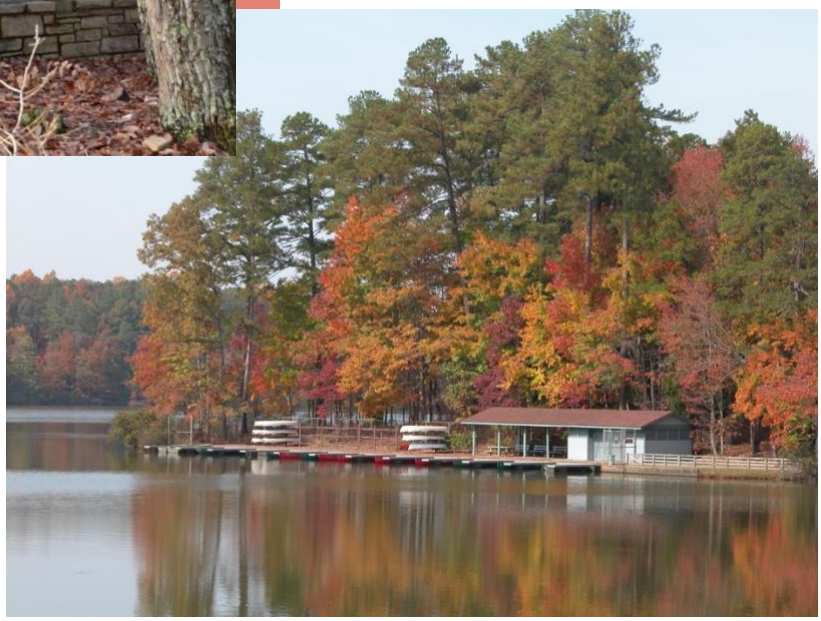


Photo Credit: Brad Young

Photo Credit: Brett Anderson



Mountains Region

Mount Mitchell State Park

"Just outside Asheville, you can climb to the top of the highest peak east of the Mississippi River at Mount Mitchell State Park. The summit of Mount Mitchell is a short but steep walk up a paved path from the parking lot near the visitor center. You can climb a stone structure on the peak for a fantastic view above the tree line. I love the views- you can often see mist and fog in the valleys below. The Blue Ridge mountains seem to go on and on in all directions. I've been atop Mount Mitchell early in the morning with only one or two other people and in the middle of the afternoon when it's full of people from all walks of life snapping selfies. There are great trails that emanate from the peak and the visitor center. A short hike takes you deep into the forest, scrambling over rocks and rhododendron roots. A visit to Mount Mitchell State Park is always a highlight of a drive along the Blue Ridge Parkway."

- **Brent Wolfe,** News Director

Photo Credit: Edward Farr

"Standing at an impressive elevation of 6,684 feet, the highest peak East of the Mississippi, Mount Mitchell State Park offers visitors stunning panoramic views of the Blue Ridge Mountains. The park is a haven for outdoor enthusiasts, with numerous trails ranging from moderate hikes to challenging treks, allowing visitors to explore its unique ecosystems and wildlife."

- **Cate Ferreira,** Mount Mitchell State Park Administrative Specialist

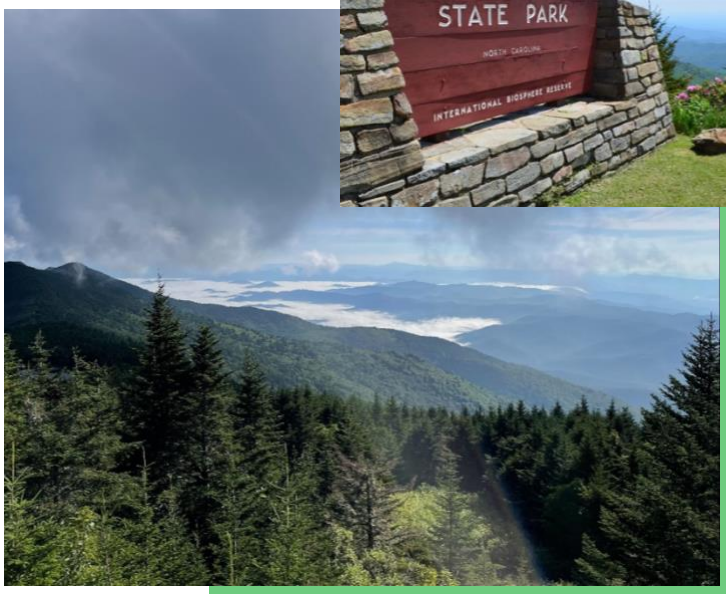


Photo Credit: Brent Wolfe

New River State Park

"When I need to hit the reset button on daily life, a trip to the North Carolina mountains always does the trick. And floating down a lazy, winding river is pure magic. New River State Park, about an hour northeast of Boone, is a favorite destination for river-tubing. The river is calm and shallow and peacefully snakes through a beautiful, lush landscape that's relatively untouched and undeveloped. There are plenty of outfitters that can haul you and your tube – or with a little planning, you can DIY it. Sit back, relax, and take in the scenery. Fun fact – contrary to its name, the New River is thought to be the second-oldest river in the world, after the Nile in Egypt. It's one of the few major rivers that flows north. So, keep track of where you are, or you'll float up into Virginia!"

- **Erin Keever,** *Due South* Executive Producer

"New River State Park offers 40 miles of river for visitors to experience through canoeing, kayaking, fishing, camping, and hiking. Although New River State Park is young, the river and namesake of the park is one of the oldest in the world. Beneath the clear mountain waters, visitors may see one of the oldest salamander species, the Hellbender."

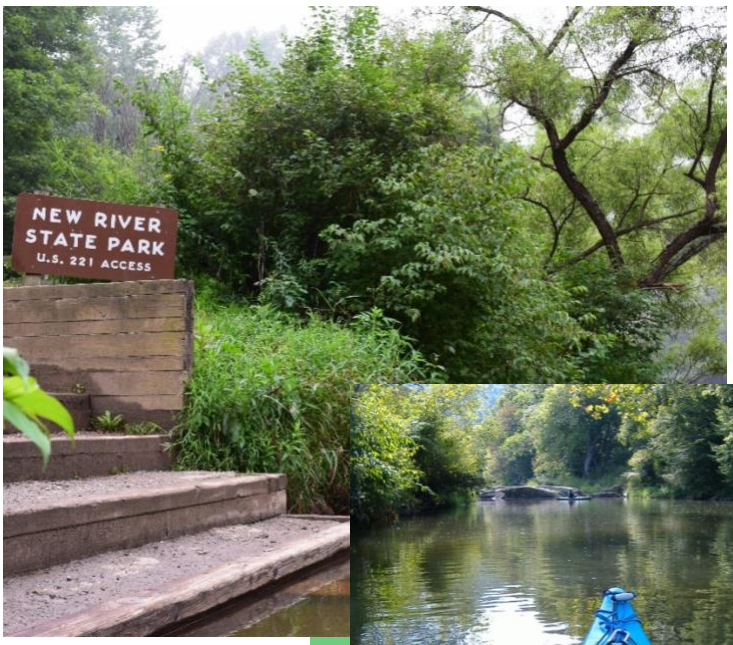


Photo Credit: Halubka, N

- **Erin Baker,** New River State Park Ranger

Photo Credit: Blatny

Stone Mountain State Park

"I've been going to Stone Mountain as long as I can remember. It's a gorgeous state park with something for everyone—hiking, nature, and the massive granite dome. It's smack in the middle of the Yadkin Valley, home to some of North Carolina's best wineries. Before or after your visit, spend some hours in my hometown of Elkin. The beautiful, historic Reeves Theatre has music and delicious food!"

- **Bradley George,**
  AM Reporter

Photo Credit: J Mickey

Photo Credit: Edward Farr

Thank you for taking this journey around the WUNC staffers' favorite North Carolina State Parks. And thanks again to the team at North Carolina State Parks for their assistance in putting this guide together! If you visit one of our recommendations, let us know! Send us an email at wunc@wunc.org or reach out via our social media accounts.

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